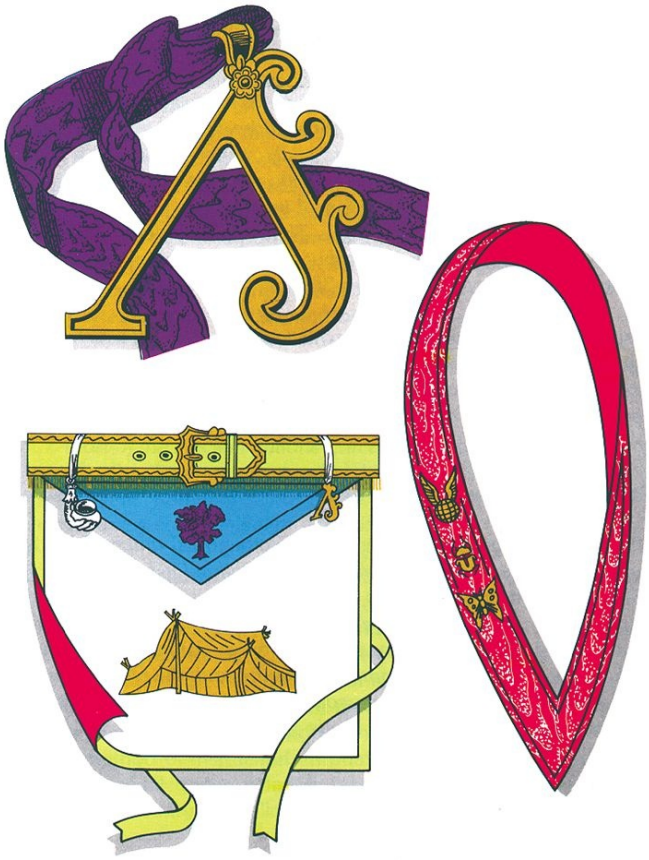
The 24th Degree – Prince of the Tabernacle



The order is a broad, watered scarlet ribbon worn from right to left. On the front is embroidered in gold, a winged–globe and under it a scarab, under which is a brilliant butterfly; all are symbols of immortality.

The girdle is of light–green morocco leather, fringed below with gold, and edged with gold lace. From this belt are suspended the jewel of the preceding degree, a silver censer, and the jewel of this degree, the Phoenician letter *Aleph*.

The apron is of white lambskin, lined with scarlet and bordered with light–green. In the middle is painted a representation of an Arabic tent, in gold. On the light blue flap is a representation of a myrtle tree of violet color, also an emblem of immortality.

The jewel is the Phoenician letter “A” (*Aleph*, *A*), suspended from a short collar of narrow, watered violet–colored ribbon. It is another manifestation of the

Pentagram, or Five–Pointed Star, because the star, viewed from any angle figures the letter “A.” Since “A” is the initial of one of the principle names of Deity, Adonai, or LORD, this star is a sign of intellectual omnipotence and autocracy.

DUTIES

Labor incessantly for the glory of God, the honor of your country and the happiness of your brethren.

LESSONS

The power of faith in the Deity and his promises. The soul is immortal.
There is one, true God, who is pure, absolute intellect and existence.

FOR REFLECTION

Is the doctrine of the immortality of the soul consoling to you or a source of menace and despair or merely a superstition?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

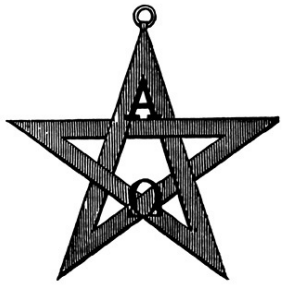
Grips of the Apprentice, Fellowcraft and Master Mason, five–pointed star, the character Caleb.

Having received the instruction of the Chief of the Tabernacle in the 23rd Degree, an adaptation of the ancient initiation into the Lesser Mysteries, we now stand on the threshold of the Greater Mysteries. The previous degree presented the Lesser Mysteries almost exclusively as a Hebrew or Judaic tradition. The mysteries were not confined to the Hebrews and here we encounter deities from the most advanced cultures and countries of the past.

CEREMONY

There are two distinct apartments or settings. The first apartment is called the Vestibule and is furnished like a Master Mason’s Lodge with the Samaritan (or ancient Hebrew) letter *yod* suspended in the East instead of the letter “G” but having the same meaning. The set in the second apartment is virtually the same

as that in the 23rd Degree with the addition of the pentagram, or five pointed star, with the Greek letters *Alpha* (*A*) and *Omega* (Ω)superimposed upon the star.



Despite the set representing the Tabernacle at the encampment of the twelve tribes of Israel in the desert, we are not confined here to Hebrew tradition in the Mysteries. The geographical range of our interest is greatly increased to show the universality of both initiation and philosophical inquiry. We also encounter a more elaborate interpretation of some of the symbolism from the three degrees of the Symbolic Lodge.

The candidate, clothed simply in a white tunic without ornaments, is received into the Vestibule, the representation of a Master Mason’s Lodge. Here he is given instruction the Master of Ceremonies, who represents Caleb. Caleb is a Biblical character who represents the incorporation of a foreign strain into the tribe of Judah. He was particularly praised as the Lord’s servant and as one who has a different spirit and has followed the Lord fully (Numbers 14:24; Deuteronomy 1:36). Through the character of Caleb, we are reminded of the acceptance of all good men into Masonry and of its universality.

Initiation is a process intended to develop in the candidate those human qualities which are part of the Divine. The three groups of lights on the altar represent: *reason*, a ray of the divine Intellect and a science which we must learn to use; *liberty* or self–control, the knowledge to defend against the instincts and a right offered to all which must be conquered; and, *faith*, a gift from God and a power which must be possessed by each. To know, to dare, to will and to be silent is the work to be done with an intellect enlightened by study, an uncheckable audacity, an unconquerable will, and an incorruptible discretion. We

are instructed to listen and learn, to search and discover—for to know the Mysteries is to stand face to face with God.

Thus advised, the candidate must undergo the tests of fire, water, earth and air, the four elements recognized by the ancients. They correspond to the agent which transforms matter (heat or fire), and the three states of matter: liquid (water), solid (earth) and gas (air). These tests are given in the East, North, South and West respectively, and as such represent the four cardinal points of material existence and also of spiritual life. In addition to the instruction of a spiritual nature about the omnipotence, beneficence and omnipresence of God, moral instruction is given with each test. The test of fire should remind us to assume only those responsibilities for which we are fitted. This association of fire and fitness for certain responsibilities comes from the Biblical story of Nadab and Abihu who were destroyed for offering strange fire before the Lord (see Leviticus 10:1 and Numbers 26:61). Water should remind us of the ancient teaching that only the pure of heart can enter the Tabernacle in heaven and that reformation and repentance wash away sin. The test of the earth in the South reminds us to be generous as the earth is beneficent even to the unworthy. In the West, the test of air should remind us to be generous and liberal like God, who freely gave the gift of air, necessary for the life of all men.

The candidate enters the Tabernacle in utter darkness and silence, a reminder of death. He hears the lamentations and sorrow associated with the deaths of selected deities—Osiris of Egypt, Kama of India, Mithra of Persia, Atys of Phrygia, and Thammuz of Phoenicia. Their deaths symbolize the temporary victory of darkness and evil over the light. The mythologies associated with all of these deities tell of both their death and resurrection.

Brethren, enacting ancient drama, mourn Osiris, who is representative of the sun, of light, of life, of good and of beauty. They reflect upon the way the earth may again be gladdened by his presence. Attempts are made to bring life to the dead Osiris with the grip of the Apprentice, a symbol of science, and with the grip of the Fellowcraft, a symbol of logic. Both logic or right and science or reason fail, for with them we cannot discover evidence of even the existence of

the soul, much less its immortality. The third attempt using the grip of the Master Mason, a symbol of faith, succeeds. Faith is a profound conviction within our intellectual and spiritual selves which enables us to somewhat understand God and to know and believe that we are to live after the body dies.

We now focus on three important philosophical issues. First, there is one true God Who is pure absolute intellect and existence and Who is the soul and spirit of the universe which He created with a thought. Everything to Him is here and now; He is unchangeable, immutable, just, wise and powerful. His punishments are but the inevitable results of the laws of cause and effect. Second, the soul is immortal and is a part of the universal soul and, if God pleases, will be absorbed again into Himself. Third, the struggle in every man's nature between the divine will implanted in every man by God and the natural will caused by the frailty of the flesh is constant and one with all the universe. This struggle is the law of harmony in action, he reconciling and bringing into accord of the spiritual and material nature of man.

These three lessons are symbolized by the pentagram or star with *Alpha* and *Omega* imposed on its surface. It is the symbol of the Divine in man. Alpha is the first letter of the Greek alphabet and Omega the last; hence, signifying completeness, the beginning and the end and all within them. The five–pointed star with a single point upward represents the Divine. It also symbolizes man for its five points allude to the five senses, the five members (head, arms and legs) and his five fingers on each hand, which signify the tokens that distinguish Masons.

Finally, the new Prince of the Tabernacle is presented to the brethren to be further instructed and prepared to fulfill all his duties in the frail tabernacle of life. The phrase "to be" infers that with additional instruction provided by the lecture in *Morals and Dogma*, he will be better fitted to perform the duties of a Prince of the Tabernacle: to labor incessantly for the glory of God, the honor of his country and the happiness of his brethren so that he may be raised on the day of account to the Tabernacle of Eternity.

LECTURE

Continuing the focus on the Ancient Mysteries, a wealth of detail on the Greater Mysteries of Egypt, Greece, Persia, Syria, Phoenicia, Chaldea, Arabia, India, China and Japan is presented. Gleaning the ideas from the detail, we learn both the purposes and lessons of the Greater Mysteries, all of which to some extent taught:

> *...the truths of primitive revelation, the existence and attributes of one God, the immortality of the Soul, rewards and punishments in a future life, the phenomena of Nature, the arts, the sciences, morality, legislation, philosophy, and philanthropy, and what we now style psychology and metaphysics, with animal magnetism, and the other occult sciences* (p. 372).

The lessons transmitted through the Mysteries are presented in a comparative fashion. Pike argues their universality and arrives at an understanding of the primitive truths known long ago. Over time these became both corrupted and concealed under multi–layered veils of symbolism. The parallel ideas which emerge from his comparative analysis point to the East for the origin of these primitive truths. Pike asserts that Hindu philosophy gave birth to the Egyptian Mysteries and to the Mysteries among the Chinese and Japanese. Thus, he sees the diffusion of these primitive truths from India across thousands of miles and a multitude of cultures. The method of instruction employed by these diverse cultures to transmit these sublime lessons was symbology. Pike tells us:

> *There has ever been an intimate alliance between the two systems, the symbolic and the philosophical, in the allegories of the monuments of all ages, in the symbolic writings of the priests of all nations, in the rituals of all secret and mysterious societies; there has been a constant series, an invariable uniformity of principles, which come from an aggregate, vast, imposing, and true, composed of parts that fit harmoniously only there* (p. 372).

The selections which follow emphasize the purposes and the lessons of the Ancient Mysteries, not the details associated with them. Since Scottish Rite Masonry uses symbolism as its method of instruction and teaches philosophical, moral, religious and political lessons, this lecture invites us to compare the teachings of Masonry with those of the Ancient Mysteries.

The Methods and Purposes of the Ancient Mysteries:

Symbolical instruction is recommended by the constant and uniform usage of antiquity; and it has retained its influence throughout all the ages, as a system of mysterious communication. The Deity, in his revelations to man, adopted the use of material images for the purpose of enforcing the sublime truths; and Christ taught by symbols and parables (p. 372).

Initiation was considered to be a mystical death; a descent into the infernal regions, where every pollution, and the stains and imperfections of a corrupt and evil life were purged away ... (p. 373).

The object of all the Mysteries was to inspire men with piety, and to console them in the miseries of life. That consolation, so afforded, was the hope of a happier future, and of passing, after death, to a state of eternal felicity (p. 379).

It is easy to see what was the great object of initiation and the Mysteries; whose first and greatest fruit was, as all the ancients testify, to civilize savage hordes, to soften their ferocious manners, to introduce among them social intercourse, and lead them into a way of life more worthy of men. ... and teach them the true principles of morals, which initiate man into the only kind of life worthy of him (pp. 380–381).

By initiation, those who before were fellow–citizens only, became brothers, connected by a closer bond than before, by means of a religious fraternity, which, bringing men nearer together, united them more strongly... (p. 386).

Initiation dissipated errors and banished misfortune: and after having filled the heart of man with joy during life, it gave him the most blissful hopes at the

moment of death (p. 386).

The Important Lessons Taught in the Ancient Mysteries:

The object of the Mysteries was to procure for man a real felicity on earth by the means of virtue; and to that end he was taught that his soul was immortal; and that error, sin, and vice must needs, by an inflexible law, produce their consequences (pp. 382–383).

... the great moral lesson of the Mysteries, to which all their mystic ceremonial tended, expressed in a single line by Virgil, was to practise Justice and revere the Deity;—thus recalling men to justice, by connecting it with the justice of the Gods, who require it and punish its infraction. The Initiate could aspire to the favors of the Gods, only because and while he respected the rights of society and those of humanity (p. 391).

It was not enough to be initiated merely. It was necessary to be faithful to the laws of initiation, which imposed on men duties in regard to their kind (p. 391).

We are only concerned with the great fact that the Mysteries taught the doctrine of the soul's immortality, and that, in some shape, suffering, pain, remorse, and agony, ever follow sin as its consequences (p. 392).

Death, says the author of the dialogue, entitled Axiochus, included in the works of Plato, is but a passage to a happier state; but one must have lived well, to attain that most fortunate result. So that the doctrine of the immortality of the soul was consoling to the virtuous and religious man alone; while to all others it came with menaces and despair, surrounding them with terrors and alarms that disturbed their repose during all their life (p. 396).

In the Mysteries was also taught the division of the Universal Cause into an Active and a Passive cause; .... These two Divinities, the Active and Passive Principles of the Universe, were commonly symbolized by the generative parts of man and woman; to which, in remote ages, no idea of indecency was attached; .... The Indian lingam was the union of both, as were the boat and mast and the

point within a circle: all of which expressed the same philosophical idea as to the Union of the two great Causes of Nature, which concur, one actively and the other passively, in the generation of all beings: ... (p. 401) .

There is another division of nature, which has in all ages struck all men, and which was not forgotten in the Mysteries; that of Light and Darkness, Day and Night, Good and Evil; which mingle with, and clash against, and pursue or are pursued by each other throughout the Universe (p. 402).

...the Mysteries also represented to the candidate, by sensible symbols, the invisible forces which move this visible Universe, and the virtues, qualities, and powers attached to matter, and which maintain the marvellous order observed therein (p. 414).

The world, according to the philosophers of antiquity, was not a purely material and mechanical machine. A great Soul, diffused everywhere, vivified all the members of the immense body of the Universe; and an Intelligence, equally great, directed all its movements, and maintained the eternal harmony that resulted therefrom (pp. 414–415).

T*he Soul, a simple substance, when unconnected with matter, a ray or particle of the Divine Fire, whose home is in Heaven, ever turns toward that home, while united with the body, and struggles to return thither.*

Teaching this, the Mysteries strove to recall man to his divine origin, and point out to him the means of returning thither. The great science acquired in the Mysteries was knowledge of man's self, of the nobleness of his origin, the grandeur of his destiny, and his superiority over animals, which can never acquire this knowledge, and whom he resembles so long as he does not reflect upon his existence and sound the depths of his own nature (p. 417).

Such were the Mysteries; ....The human mind still speculates upon the great mysteries of nature, and still finds its ideas anticipated by the ancients, whose profoundest thoughts are to be looked for, not in their philosophies, but in their symbols, by which they endeavored to express the great ideas that vainly

struggled for utterance in words, as they viewed the great circle of phenomena, – Birth, Life, Death, or Decomposition, and New Life out of Death and Rottenness, —to them the greatest of mysteries (p. 434).



TEMPTATION IN EDEN
by Albrecht Durer

As the first of the Greater Mystery degrees, this degree teaches the paradox of the existence of good and evil in a universe created by an infinitely beneficent Deity. The story of the Garden of Eden in Genesis is, in the Western religious tradition, the explanation of the origin of evil in man. This story teaches that, as a result of disobedience to God, man must now continually struggle against his evil nature. In the above 16th century woodcut the temptor is Satan in the guise of a serpent. There is no evidence that the early Israelites considered this serpent to be a form of Satan. Such an interpretation is Christian and derives from the descriptions of Satan as a serpent or dragon in the New Testament (Rev. 12:9; 20:2).